

The Rutgers School

A Zerubavelian Culturalist Cognitive Sociology

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Abstract

In this article, the Zerubavelian culturalist cognitive paradigm which comprises an emerging Rutgers School of Sociology is presented. This perspective employs a comparative cognitive pluralist approach to the study of cognition and takes as its central premise that the mind is social. The key roots of the perspective in Simmelian classical sociology and in the twentieth-century sociology of knowledge approaches of Fleck, Mannheim, Berger and Luckmann and others are outlined. The key concepts and parameters of the field and its concern with perception, attention, classification, meaning-making, memory, time and identity are discussed. Finally, its methodological approach is outlined and it is suggested that the Zerubavelian perspective provides a unique analytic literacy that cuts across the various subfields of contemporary sociology.

Key words

■ cognitive sociology ■ meaning ■ Rutgers School ■ sociological methods ■ sociological theory ■ sociology of knowledge

As a former student and intellectual descendant of Eviatar Zerubavel, I am honored to represent his important tradition of cognitive sociology. Zerubavel (1997) has already provided an excellent overview of what his brand of cognitive sociology contributes to our understanding of human cognition, but a similar statement on what the Rutgers School has contributed to sociological theory and to sociology is needed. I build upon Zerubavel's (1997) statement on cognitive sociology and his methodological statements (see Zerubavel, 1980, 2007) to define and articulate this exciting school of thought.

In substance, Zerubavelian culturalist cognitive sociology studies the socio-mental conventions by which we perceive, attend to, and disattend to features of social reality, classify and categorize the world, create meaning, construct identity, remember events and comprehend time (see Zerubavel, 1993: 389; 1997). While these might be considered the substantive domain of culturalist

cognitive sociology, it is also a 'theoretical method' (Nippert-Eng, 1996: 291) or an 'analytic literacy' that cuts across the many substantive specialties of sociology. Cognitive sociology is a broadly applicable perspective that provides key insights into how groups of people construct the culture that mediates meanings for individuals. The development of the 'cognitive sociological imagination' (Zerubavel, 2007) is an important trend in sociological thought. Zerubavel's approach is translatable across nearly any subfield of sociological inquiry. It can be used to analyze identity, classification, race, religion, education, deviance, sexuality, culture, memory, social movements and just about any other social arena. It can be applied to ethnographic, historical/comparative, quantitative, and content or discourse analyses and is itself a combined theory and methodology that can be integrated with other methods.

Culturalist cognitive sociology focuses on the use of culture in everyday life by the actual participants in and consumers of culture, rather than only the producers of culture (DiMaggio, 1997). It brings us down to the level of culture where it happens rather than leaving us at the level of culture as a set of abstract norms, rules, or values. DiMaggio argues that interpretive sociological studies have offered great insights but failed to build on one another and that cultural theory has become highly sophisticated but not operational; he calls for scholars to study lived culture by clarifying the cognitive presuppositions about the nature of culture itself and what it does to the ways we look at identity, classification, memory, framing, and logics of action.

The cognitive turn in social theory has brought with it a number of changes to the discipline and the way we do sociological theory. Most notably, it has changed the way sociologists study culture. They no longer leave the study of everyday people living out and transmitting culture and enacting cultural lenses to anthropology. Today sociology is beginning to focus more on culture and cognition. The Rutgers School that I outline here is a leader in this trend. I focus on the Zerubavelian cognitive perspective in the following ways: First, I identify some of the key roots of the Zerubavel/Rutgers School in Simmelian thought and later in the ideas of Fleck, Mannheim, Berger and Luckmann and Goffman. Second, I discuss the nature and scope of the field, highlighting cognitive processes it studies, in particular identity construction, classification, meaning, and memory, and identifying the key concepts and directions of this exciting line of research. Finally, I discuss the Zerubavelian methodological approach of 'social pattern analysis' (Zerubavel, 2007) with special attention to the way that current cognitive scholars have combined social pattern analysis with ethnographic methods and other forms of data analysis to produce general theories on the socio-cognitive organization of social life.

Roots of the Zerubavelian/Rutgers School

It is not men in general who think, or even isolated individuals who do the thinking, but men in certain groups who have developed a particular style of thought . . . Strictly

speaking it is incorrect to say that the single individual thinks. Rather it is more correct to insist that he participates in thinking further what other men have thought before him. (Mannheim [1929] 1936: 3)

The reality of everyday life further presents itself to me as an intersubjective world, a world that I share with others. This intersubjectivity sharply differentiates everyday life from other realities of which I am conscious. I am alone in the world of my dreams, but I know that the world of everyday life is as real to others as it is to my self. (Berger and Luckmann, 1966: 23)

When we consider our 'mental memberships in various social communities' – race, nationality, religion, language, profession, level of education, generation, political party etc. – the extent to which we look at the world and together form our 'social mindscapes' becomes immediately apparent. (Zerubavel, 2000: 8)

With the publication of *Social Mindscapes*, Eviatar Zerubavel (1997) formally introduces cognitive sociology and explains why it answers questions that cognitive science cannot answer. Zerubavel (1997: 2–3) highlights the need for cognitive sociology to account for aspects of cognition that are neither cognitive universals (the domain of cognitive scientists) nor the cognitively individualist idiosyncracies of particular individuals (the domain of psychoanalysts). Sociology's promise for the study of cognition is to demonstrate those elements of cognition that are fundamentally social and thus neither the product of unique individual nuances nor universals of the human mind. One might think of this as the sociological equivalent to linguists who look neither at the idiolect of the individual nor at the language universals, but at the language or the dialect.¹ Human beings think as 'social beings' and, as such, cognitive sociologists are uniquely qualified to study this socially networked aspect of the mind.

Zerubavelian sociology complements the work of cognitive scientists by showing that we think not only as human beings but also as social beings located in particular cultures and subcultures, and belonging to particular 'thought communities.'² Although cognitive scientists show that the need to classify the world is a species universal, a culturalist cognitive sociology shows us how the particular categories we construct, the classification conventions we use and the 'ideological cartography'³ of meaning therein are socially, culturally and subculturally constructed (DiMaggio, 1997; Zerubavel, 1991). Cerulo (2002: 17) notes that the contributions of cognitive sociology 'suggest that sensation and attention may be as much socioculturally scripted as they are innately inscribed.' Sociology complements the work of the cognitive sciences by showing how culture mediates the natural in shaping how we perceive and organize our realities.

Cognitive individualism and cognitive universalism represent two poles of a continuum with respect to how we observe and think about cognitive phenomena (Zerubavel, 1997; LaRossa et al., 2004). Between the poles of individual cognition and human cognition lies the domain of the culturalist cognitive perspective; this perspective recognizes the important ways that culture shapes human thought processes. Rather than the cognitive individualism of psychoanalysis or the cognitive universalism of cognitive science, a culturalist cognitive sociology

finds the middle-ground of ‘cognitive pluralism’ (Larossa et al., 2004). This perspective takes as its starting premise that people are shaped by their communities and their active identities. A further key premise is that much of our thinking is done as social actors in a particular social and cultural milieu – this shapes our perceptions and understandings. We do not think as members of just one thought community, however, because our minds are shaped by multiple group and identity affiliations and multiple social standpoints from which we view our world. Modernity embeds us in multiple thought communities; therefore we have a complex ‘web of sociomental affiliations’ (Zerubavel, 1997: 17).

Simmel’s (1955: 125–95) notion of a web of group affiliations is among the earliest intellectual roots of what developed into the culturalist cognitive sociological paradigm. Simmel saw individuality as the product of our many intersecting social group affiliations. If we could define a person’s ethnic, social, religious, familial, geographic, occupational and multiple other affiliations that make up whom they are and how they view the world, we could get a sense of who they are as individuals and how they perceive the world. The cognitive pluralism in the Zerubavelian perspective that defines itself against a cognitive individualism (which sees individuals as creating their own worlds from scratch) and against cognitive universalism (which assumes that all individuals perceive the world in a universal way) derives from the Simmelian view of individuals as made up of a pluralistic range of affiliations that shape who they are and how they see the world.

Ludwik Fleck ([1935] 1979: 38–51) first used the terms ‘thought collective’ and ‘thought community’ in his discussion of the sociology of scientific knowledge. He draws upon Durkheim’s notion that the collective is more than the sum of individuals⁴ in asking about language, ‘whose thought is it that continues to circulate? It is one that obviously belongs not to any single individual but to the collective’ (Fleck, [1935] 1979: 42). Fleck further argued that ‘truth’ in science was related to the thinking style of particular thought collectives who exchanged ideas and who co-developed similar thought styles and world-views that shaped the ways that they perceived empirical reality.

Mannheim (1936: 79–81) further developed the idea that people think as members of collectives and that their social standpoints are the product of their social location. For Mannheim, humans think in social contexts, and their mental structures are shaped by their social contexts and their affiliations with social groups. Mannheim conceived of ideologies and world-views resulting not only from classes but also from myriad social standpoint affiliations such as professions, generations and status groups.

Shibutani (1955) used the notion of reference groups to get at perception, arguing that reference groups served both a normative function in defining the boundaries of acceptable behavior and exerting control over their members’ behaviors and a comparative function wherein an individual checks his world-view by comparing it to the views of others around him.

Borrowing Schutz’s (1967: 97–138) concept of ‘intersubjectivity’, Berger and Luckmann (1966: 23) suggest that between the subjective, personal world and the objective, external world lie shared intersubjective worlds that individuals

have in common with others around them. They do not share these realities in full in every way but they do take part in maintaining a common sense knowledge about the world with others around them whom are similarly located culturally, socially and structurally. Berger and Luckmann's (1966: 44–5) idea of relevance structures wherein world-views are shaped by one's immediate pragmatic interests and by one's general situation in society suggests that perception and imperception, and attention and disattention are tied closely to social location. These ideas represent some of the roots of the culturalist cognitive interest in the sociology of perception and attention. Goffman's (1974) *Frame Analysis*, in examining the framing of relevance and thus also irrelevance, further develops the idea that attention to what is in-frame and disattention to what is out of frame are socially constructed within our thought communities and among our social networks.

Parameters, Concepts and Key Works of the Zerubavel/Rutgers School

The main thought processes that the Rutgers School of cognitive sociology addresses include perception, attention and inattention, memory, time reckoning, classification, meaning and identity construction. Central to the culturalist cognitive study of perception is the idea that the world enters our senses in socially mediated ways so that how we mentally perceive the world is largely the process of the 'optical communities' we belong to and the 'optical socialization' we receive in those communities (Zerubavel, 1997: 32–3). Zerubavel uses the term 'optical communities' to refer to those thought communities that shape our world-views and the ways we perceive the social world around us. In this usage the term 'optical' refers to our mental perception of the world and not our literal visual eyesight-based perception of the world. We perceive things not through our own unique mental lens, but through the shared lens of those around us and in our social networks. Optical communities train members in their own optical traditions of viewing the world and their own styles of thought so that their members have a shared, or at least partially-shared, world-view (Zerubavel, 1997: 33). The social mind, shaped by our web of socio-mental affiliations, filters awareness into socially and culturally approved normative modes, sifting out the culturally and subculturally irrelevant and letting in culturally and subculturally approved modes of perception.⁵ For example, members of Alcoholics Anonymous and other recovery groups are trained to perceive their addiction as a disease and to create accounts of their problem that follow a narrative plotline shared with other members of the organization.⁶ Similarly, in communities dealing with domestic abuse the abused defines her/himself as a victim, a survivor, or someone who has transformed from victim to survivor depending on what optical community s/he belongs to (Germana, 2006).

In studying attention and inattention, culturalist cognitive sociologists translate the visual psychology concepts of 'figure' and 'ground' to the sociological

realm in looking at what we socially and mentally foreground and background in the ways that we perceive, interpret, and attend to the social world around us. Building upon Goffman's *Frame Analysis*, the cognitive sociological focus on attention and disattention recognizes that we typically frame mental fences around our social reality, regarding most things as 'out of frame' and unworthy of our attention (Zerubavel, 1997: 37; Goffman, 1974: 201–46). Goffman's (1963: 83–8) concept of 'civil inattention' is one of the first attempts to sociologically explain those things lay social actors tactfully ignore in everyday life. Zerubavel's (2006) *Elephant in the Room: Silence and Denial* gives us a systematic approach to conscious inattention, examining conspiracies of silence, the rules of denial and agreed-upon irrelevance and the politics of denial. Purcell (1996) examines and demonstrates the norms of attention and disattention in standardizing, leveling and handicapping sporting events, noting that some variables are regarded as irrelevant, while others are treated as significant variables or proxy variables that affect the outcome of a contest. With respect to attention and disattention in the academic and scientific communities, cognitive sociologists have followed in the footsteps of Fleck ([1935] 1979) and Kuhn (1962) in noticing that 'thought communities' of scholarship also attend to and disattend to different features of social reality in culturally, subculturally and disciplinarily-mediated ways (see Zerubavel, 1995). Using a cognitive sociology of attention and disattention, for instance, I have argued that American sociology has devoted greater epistemological attention to politically salient and ontologically uncommon features of social life and that this has shaped the way that sociologists and their audiences attend to and understand the social world (Brekhus, 1998).

Zerubavelian cognitive sociologists have also contributed to our understandings of memory, time and chronology. In analyzing memory, culturalist cognitive sociologists look at how our thought communities shape and discipline our memories so that it is not our individual experiences so much as our social experiences that shape how we remember the past. Different societies have varying starting points and endpoints to historically significant events; they 'mnemonically socialize' their members into recognizing certain beginning and endpoints, particular continuities and breaks in time, and specific plotlines to understanding the past.⁷ The Zerubavelian approach allows for an analysis of 'mnemonic battles'⁸ between various thought communities that mentally approach the past in various and competing ways and with radically different perceptions of starting points, turning points, and endpoints. The sequencing of events is also an important issue in the cognitive sociology of time. Cerulo (1998: 6) demonstrates, for instance, that storytellers' narrative sequences about violence adhere to cultural scripts or sequential plotlines related to whether or not the narrator wants to portray the violence as deviant, ambiguous or normal and as unacceptable or acceptable. Ryan (2006) shows the power inherent in sequential timing by demonstrating that norms of notification about events carry with them significant meanings related to who was told what, when and where. Zerubavelian cognitive sociologists also study the division of time into sacred and profane, or marked and unmarked, times and the meanings associated with the social marking and division of time.⁹

One of the ways Rutgers School sociologists examine the social mind is to look at the socio-cultural components of discrimination and classification (see Cerulo, 2002: 61) and at the ways that we carve up reality into discrete chunks to form 'islands of meaning' (Zerubavel, 1991: 5–32). Our classification systems and our use of metaphors in classifying the world are the products of cultural sensitization and socialization into social rules of relevance and irrelevance. Simpson (1996) demonstrates, for instance, how the classification of safety and danger is intersubjective and only loosely related to an objective assessment of what is statistically safe or dangerous. Although the world we live in is continuous, we experience it in terms of discrete chunks of meaning (Zerubavel, 1996: 421). Applying the ideas of 'lumping' and 'splitting' from taxonomic classifications of species, wherein 'lumpers' look for similarities and 'splitters' for ever increasing differentiation, sociologists look at the ways that social actors lump and split in classifying their social realities. Social actors use a non-metric, topological mode of thinking to look at the world, wherein they exaggerate inter-cluster mental distances and play down intracluster differences (Zerubavel, 1996: 421). By looking at the classification of various phenomena Zerubavelian/Rutgers cognitive sociologists highlight the processes that social actors use to carve out an intersubjective, culturally mediated reality from a natural world.

Related to classification, cognitive sociologists look at meaning making. One of the most important developments in this regard is the concept of *social markedness* and its parallel *social unmarkedness*.¹⁰ In many forms of meaning-making there is a cultural distinction between the ordinary (the semiotically unmarked) and the special (the semiotically marked) (Zerubavel (1997:74).¹¹ Sociologists apply the concept of markedness from linguistic contrasts to social contrasts to show how the social mind actively foregrounds one side of a contrast while only passively defining the other side by its absence of markedness (Brekhus, 1996: 500). The ability to perceive and attend to things revolves around their social markedness (Mullaney, 2006: 4). The idea of markedness was first introduced in linguistics by Jakobson and Trubetzkoy (1975) who used the terms marked and unmarked to describe the asymmetrical relationship within phoneme pairs, wherein one side is actively highlighted while the other is defined solely by its absence of a mark (Brekhus, 1996: 500; Mullaney, 2006: 4). The existence of the contrast is a general social principle but the content of the contrasted entities is context-dependent (Zerubavel, 1997: 74).

The concepts of markedness and unmarkedness are especially relevant to issues of social identity.¹² In my own research on the social organization of identity (Brekhus, 2003) for example, I use the identity-making realities of suburban gay men in the New York City area as an empirical site to look at how people who have competing marked and unmarked identity attributes balance them to construct and present an identity. In combining two general thought communities in the United States – 'gay men' and 'suburbanites' – I explore how people with intersecting identities of socially salient minority status (gays) and socially taken-for-granted majority status (suburbanites) organize their world-views around competing attributes of stigma and privilege. From this research I was

able to discover a general structure of identity grammar wherein social actors treat identity attributes either as a noun (something they are), as a verb (something they spatially and temporally commute to and from), or as an adjective (something that describes a small part of them) and that each of these identity grammars has a different configuration of identity duration and identity density (or intensity) associated with the attribute. I developed the concepts of 'identity lifestylers' (people who treat an identity attribute as an all-defining, essentializing noun), 'identity commuters' (people who travel in and out of separate identity-worlds, playing up each identity attribute as a verb in its appropriate social context and playing it down in other contexts) and 'identity integrators' (people who mix multiple identity attributes together as each a small modifying adjective that shapes a multidimensional whole). Although the identity attributes actors organize as lifestylers, commuters, and integrators varies by social, cultural and historical context, the framework for understanding the social organization of identity can be applied across multiple contexts. Recently Schnoor (2006) has extended this analysis to examine intersectionality and identity among Jewish gay men in Toronto, illustrating that they may organize themselves as Jewish lifestylers (where Jewish identity takes center stage), gay lifestylers (where gayness is foregrounded over Jewishness), gay-Jewish commuters (who travel back and forth between the two identities) and gay-Jewish integrators (who combine the two identities rather than foregrounding one or the other).

The Zerubavelian cognitive approach brings unique things to the sociology of identity that are missing from some established traditions. Much of the sociological analysis of identity has focused on politically salient collective identity attributes such as race, class and gender which Appiah and Gates (1995: 1) refer to as the 'holy trinity' within identity analysis (see also Cerulo, 1997: 385). These works are heavily shaped by the tradition of 'standpoint theory' deriving from feminism (Smith, 1987; Hill-Collins, 1990) with earlier roots in Marxism, that argues that individuals' social locations on the axes of gender, race and class shape how they experience and see the world. Standpoint theorists demonstrate that social marginality along these axes produces a unique perspective on the world. The culturalist cognitive sociologist accepts the premise of standpoint theory that social location shapes one's perspective and that intersecting social locations complicate one's standpoint, but suggests that standpoints are shaped not only by the salient characteristics of race, class and gender, but also by membership in social categories that are not necessarily salient to sociologists or to social movements recognized by them.

While much social standpoint theory traces its intellectual roots back to a Marxian tradition of recognizing that social classes have different interests and thus competing world-views, the culturalist cognitive sociologist traces her/his roots back to Simmel. Although rarely discussed as such, Simmel's *Conflict and the Web of Group Affiliations* was actually among the first sociological works to deal explicitly with the issues of social standpoint and intersectionality (see Simmel, 1955: 140–3). While many sociologists lump people together along race, class, gender, and sexuality grounds, the cognitive sociologist steps back to

also consider identity attributes that, while not politically salient among sociologists or among the most visible social movements that sociologists attend to, may shape the world-views of social actors (see Brekhus, 1998: 48). Lamont (1995: 1) found, for instance, that while sociologists saw race and class as their most important defining characteristics, her actual respondents among lower middle-class African-American and Euro-American men saw their 'moral self-definition' as the most important identity attribute by which they identified themselves and identified with others. Similarly my own analysis of meaning-making and identity construction found that many suburban gay men did not see themselves primarily in terms of their sexuality but in terms of their degree of 'urbanness'. Thus they were as likely to vote as suburbanites, see New York City from the viewpoint of a suburbanite, and organize their lives around suburbanite as a defining aspect of themselves as they were to vote as a gay man, view New York City from the perspective of a gay man, and organize their lives as a gay man.¹³

Cognitive sociology contributes to identity research by cutting across different kinds of identities to find formal similarities in their organization. The methodology of the cognitive sociologist when studying identity is to look for social patterns in the communities one studies and to see if the same patterns are operative across other communities. This kind of analysis, known as 'social pattern analysis' (Zerubavel, 2007) may sometimes begin with analysis within specific intersubjective contexts but it moves out to provide a satellite view of the transcontextual patterns underlying the social realities that the specific contexts lay bare. Although specific mindscapes are formed by the culture, subculture, or thought community, culturalist cognitive sociology tries to tease out the underlying processes of categorization, attention/disattention, and identity construction from the complex intersubjective meaning systems they produce within localized contexts.

Methodology: Social Pattern Analysis, Analytic Highlight Reels, and the Cognitive Sociological Imagination

Building upon the idea that human beings think as members of culturally and subculturally mediated thought communities, culturalist cognitive sociology begins with examples of intersubjective reality-making and then compares across intersubjective realities from disparate social contexts to articulate general patterns of social cognition. Culturalist cognitive sociologists illuminate both the archetypal structures and their transmutations via culture into socially constructed reality to try to shed light on what constitutes a cultural realization versus what is truly common across cultures. We show that there are certain cognitive processes and acts used by everyone, but we are convinced by the sheer diversity of where the lines are drawn and where the boxes and boundaries lie that the cognitive tools people use are applied quite differently across cultural groupings and among individuals belonging to multiple cultures, subcultures or thought communities. The meanings we find show the importance of cultural and subcultural variation in what people attend to and disattend to, what

identity attributes they consider salient and what ones they ignore, how they classify reality, and how they remember the past. At the same time they demonstrate formal similarities in the socio-mental processes that evoke different subcultural and cultural meanings. These formal similarities are what might be termed the deep structural patterns of socio-cognitive life (see Zerubavel, 2007). For the culturalist cognitive sociologist, the substance of these structural patterns is a matter of social convention, but the form is the product of socio-cognitive organization patterns that occur across subcultural, historical, and cultural contexts. Therefore in addition to cross-cultural variation in what specific things people make meaning of, we look for generalizable similarities in how people make their intersubjective meanings within specific thought communities.

A Zerubavelian cognitive sociology traces not only its substantive roots back to the Simmelian tradition but also its methodological roots. The Zerubavelian perspective uses the method of formal sociology wherein social life is examined for its similar analytic formal features across substantively different social contexts.¹⁴ Important to this tradition is the observation of social forms at different levels of scale and content (Zerubavel, 2007). In the ideal, the Zerubavelian cognitive sociologist collects evidence across multiple contexts and uses a comparative method to generate analysis across these disparate social contexts. Rather than look only for the specificities and differences between cultures, we look for underlying patterns that shape these specificities. Whereas the balkanization of American sociology has caused many researchers to 'split' into specialized subfields such as organizations, deviance, religion, race, or gender, the Zerubavelian theoretical method strives to 'lump' together, for the purposes of analysis, various institutional and identity contexts, and various levels of macro and micro analysis that are usually regarded as too substantively different or too different in scale to be related (Zerubavel, 2007).

Because we are interested in the formal patterns of culturally mediated cognition, Zerubavelian cognitive sociologists often use typologies to highlight form. Nippert-Eng (1996) develops the typology of 'segmentors' and 'integrators' to illustrate that people organize their occupational and home identities along a continuum from complete segmentation of two worlds to complete integration of those worlds. Davis (1983) develops a typology of Gnosticism, Naturalism, and Jehovanism to illustrate that cultural and political disputes over sexuality are generally a dispute over what temporal point of sexuality defines the essence of the sexual act. Davis also points to the conflicts and tensions between socio-mental standpoints, showing that competing thought communities battle over their differing windows on reality. DeGloma (2005) similarly shows that the dialectically opposed socio-mental standpoints of survivor movements and counter-movements lead to intense 'cognitive battles'¹⁵ over contested definitions of reality.

Methodologically the culturalist cognitive sociologist is interested in the breadth of the territory of social life covered so as to uncover the cognitive structures and the form of the cognitive conventions that social actors use to socially construct their specific cultural realities. Thus rather than developing a thick and deep empirical description of a narrow slice of social life, s/he is interested

in an analytically deep analysis that covers a wide empirical range of social life. Zerubavel's (1991) analysis of the ways we create categories and boundaries across multiple thought communities and across multiple institutional contexts (law, science, and religion) and from many levels of analysis is an example of the study of classification in its purest deep analysis form. Whereas the classic ethnographer seeks thick description and thin but widely spread analysis of a specific social setting so that it is understood in all its contours and details, the cognitive sociologist prefers *thick analysis* and thin but widely spread description of social settings that reveal the analytic principles being studied.¹⁶

The flexibility of the Zerubavelian approach is that it can also be employed in more focused ethnographic contexts to highlight theoretical possibilities and to develop broad general social theory. In my ethnographic research, for instance, I employed an ethnographic case study to develop a theory on the socio-cognitive organization of identity; in utilizing Zerubavelian cognitive sociology as a 'theoretical method' I focused on 'analytic highlight reels' (Brekhus, 2003: 8) of informants' meaning-making and identity construction, rather than attend to a full play-by-play account of each detail of informants' lives and social settings. The play-by-play ethnographic approach commonly known as 'thick description' (Geertz, 1973) is data-driven and emphasizes describing one's empirical data in all its detail (Brekhus, 2003: 7–8). The thick descriptivist ethnographer attempts to flatten out all of the ethnographer's own culturally-bound assumptions in a sometimes unrealistic and unnecessary move toward a *tabula rasa* that assumes that all data is new and that the previous knowledge of the ethnographer must be suspended entirely. The analytic highlight reel approach, by contrast, is theme-driven and requires the analyst to isolate thematic highlights from the data. It is an epistemological acknowledgement of our ability to find patterns based on our own trained attention as researchers to multiple social worlds – a risky 'vote of confidence' or 'license to generalize' for the researcher in an era where generalizing and thinking beyond one's case is often disparaged as a denial of the uniqueness of the specific groups we study.

In the social pattern analysis of Zerubavelian cognitive analysis the choice of settings is theme-driven rather than substance-driven. Thus, in contrast to the classical ethnographer who is in essence a qualitative 'data dredger' entering the field as close to *tabula rasa* as possible with the intent of seeing what emerges from the data, the cognitive sociologist enters the setting with a well-defined analytic strategy.¹⁷ One of the keys to this strategy is to compare data based on formal similarities rather than substantive similarities. Thus, for example, in her study of 'de-labelers', Howard (2006) ignores the substantive differences in a wide range of diagnostic labels such as agoraphobic, alcoholic, anorexic, bulimic, co-dependent, depressive and social phobic, to develop a general theory of identifying and de-identifying with diagnostic labels. Likewise Mullaney's (2006) study of identities based on 'not-doings' focuses on abstinence around substantively very different phenomena such as driving, alcohol, meat, sex, drugs, sweets, television and technology. She highlights the formal rather than the substantive features among abstainers, by differentiating them along the dimensions of *when* they

abstain (before or after doing something) and *how long* they abstain (whether they abstain temporarily or permanently) rather than along what they abstain from. She breaks down abstiners along the many dimensions of things one can abstain from into nevers, waiters, time-outers, and quitters, showing that these forms of abstention are cognitively similar across the substantively unique activities from which one abstains. Such methods of analysis that get at formal rather than substantive features of social life, can help us to explain or even predict how social actors are likely to experience social life, some aspect being based on what others in a *cognitively*, but not *substantively*, similar situation have done.

Conclusion: Zerubavelian Cognitive Sociology as an Analytic Literacy

I refer to Zerubavel's cognitive sociology as an 'analytic literacy' because, like method or theory it is a tool that can be employed across substantive subfields of sociology. It is an analytic method for focusing on the cognitive cornerstones of cultural thinking that can be employed to study a wide range of thought communities at the subcultural, cultural, and societal levels. The Rutgers School is itself an 'optical community' that has been optically socialized to see the generic patterns of social life using methods of theoretical analysis that transcend conventional ways of thinking within the discipline.¹⁸ Because sociologists trained in the Rutgers School are not optically constrained to limit their thinking inside the conventional intradisciplinary boundaries within sociology, they develop an analytic creativity and a nomadic perspective that is often lacking in more conventional 'filling in a gap in the literature' types of scholarship. Zerubavelian sociologists are socialized into an 'analytic nomadism' (Brekhus, 1998: 47–8) that encourages moving across disciplinary subfields and across levels of scale and substance to map the topography of the social landscape from multiple vantage points. Trained to 'lump together' and find similarity in disparate cases and levels of analysis rather than to split apart and find difference, and to generalize rather than particularize from their specific cases, Zerubavelian cognitive sociologists are optically socialized to see outside taken-for-granted variables and demographic boxes. The introduction of a Simmelian-based standpoint theory that takes intersectionality seriously along a much wider range of dimensions than race, class and gender provides a more thoroughly cognitively pluralist approach than one limited to just the more socially and politically salient variables. This socialization into thinking that cuts across the disciplinary grain, allows for the opening of new mental vistas that are invisible from mainstream epistemological vantage points. The Zerubavelian cognitive approach is not a rejection of conventional sociological methods but rather a style of analysis that enhances and complements standard methodologies by introducing a creative component and an epistemological shift or new angle to our ways of thinking about social phenomena.

Among the challenges facing Zerubavelian cognitive sociologists is that the field of sociology often takes universal categorical difference implicitly as its

starting point when examining demographic variables. Indeed, in quantitative analysis difference is often necessary to produce a statistically significant result and therefore a finding. As such, the idea of looking for formal similarities across disparate thought communities and different demographic categories is likely to face challenges from researchers engaged in the more established practice of searching for and accentuating demographic difference. The search for demographic difference and statistical significance on the variables of race, class and gender overcomes the cognitive universalism of the 'universal everyman' approach, but amounts to a soft cognitive universalism by implying uniformity within large and internally diverse demographic categories whose members may have multiple webs of socio-mental affiliation. Zerubavelian cognitive sociologists open up the possibilities for understanding world-views and identities in the modern world by extending analysis to a broad range of culturally created but nonetheless socially real thought communities such as religions, occupations, neighborhood types, institutional settings, and subcultural groups as they intersect and compete with the more disciplinarily salient demographic categories of race, class and gender.

The Rutgers School of sociology looks at a variety of issues through its unique cognitive analytic lens. Its areas of interest include perception, the social organization of relevance and attention, classification conventions, meaning-making, memory and chronology, and identity construction. The approach draws upon a Simmelian notion of standpoint and intersectionality that privileges multiple intersecting 'thought communities' including those often ignored because they are not formed around demographic variables of interest tied to race, gender and class. As can be seen by the broad range of topics covered in this 'subfield' – such as the cognitive structure of right and wrong in the use of violence (Cerulo, 1998), cognitive battles between competing epistemological world-views on sexuality (Davis, 1983) and the organization of identity (Brekhus, 2003), the creation of physically separated communities of the mind over time and space (Chayko, 2002), the temporal norms of notification patterns (Ryan, 2006), the social structure of memory (Vinitzky-Seroussi, 1998: 78–89; Zerubavel, 2003), the structural and cultural factors that affect the creation of national symbols and anthems (Cerulo, 1995), the negotiation of home and work boundaries (Nippert-Eng, 1996), the construction of identities based on abstinence (Mullaney, 2006) and de-labeling (Howard, 2006), and the epistemological foundations of academic attention (Zerubavel, 1995; Brekhus, 1998) – it cuts across disciplinary subfields. The Rutgers School provides a theoretical/methodological approach for looking at the social world that transcends boundaries of substantive content and scale. Zerubavelian cognitive sociology is not only a field of substantive inquiry, but a unique analytic and epistemological literacy in the sociological imagination.

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Notes

- 1 See Chomsky (1965) for a language universalist view. See Pinker (1994) for a somewhat less universalist view but one that holds that the innate grammatical machine of language is universal. I thank Rachel Brekhus for suggesting this linguistic parallel.
- 2 See Zerubavel (1997:9) on 'thought communities' and Fleck (1979 [1935]) on 'thought collectives'.
- 3 For more on this topic, see Brunnsma (forthcoming).
- 4 See Durkheim on the 'collective conscience' (1947 [1893]: 130).
- 5 For a discussion of socio-mental filtering and how it shapes perception, see DeGloma and Friedman (2005).
- 6 For more on this topic, see Howard (2000, 2006).
- 7 Zerubavel (1997:87; 2003:4–5) uses the term 'mnemonic socialization' to refer to the ways we are socialized by our various thought communities to adhere to cultural norms of remembrance. For an excellent analysis of the fundamentally social nature of memory. See especially Zerubavel (2003).
- 8 This phrase is found in Zerubavel (1997: 97–9; 2003: 2).
- 9 On the division of time, see Zerubavel (1979, 1985:101–166). For a discussion of time periodization, see Zerubavel (2003: 82–100). See Isaacson (1996) on different constructions of time in debates over fetuses, infants, and 'fetus-infants' and Foster (1996) on the construction and mapping of menstrual time.
- 10 For a discussion of social markedness and social unmarkedness, see Brekhus (1996, 1998); Mullaney (2006); Waugh (1982).
- 11 For a discussion of the distinction between marked and unmarked days, see Zerubavel (1985:113–120).
- 12 For the concepts of markedness and unmarkedness applied to identity, see, for example, Brekhus (1996, 2003), Jones (2001), Mullaney (1999, 2001, 2006).
- 13 I have discussed the organization of identity construction in Brekhus (2003: 67–71, 74–94).
- 14 For an excellent discussion of the Simmelian methodological roots of the Zerubavelian paradigm, see Zerubavel (2007) and Zerubavel (1980).
- 15 Zerubavel (1997:12) uses the term 'cognitive battles' to refer to battles between competing social camps or thought communities. For an example of cognitive battles over identity, see Brekhus (2003: 99–122, 157–214).
- 16 For the different uses of thinness and thickness in qualitative research, see Brekhus, Galliher and Gubrium (2005).
- 17 The strategy of starting with sensitizing analytic concepts and a pre-determined idea of what one is looking for is sometimes controversial in qualitative sociology which is heavily data-driven. By contrast, in quantitative sociology the idea is to first develop a theory about what is going on and then test that theory in social life. In the quantitative tradition those who gather data first are accused of 'data-dredging.'
- 18 I thank Jenna Howard for her observation that the Rutgers School is an 'optical community' with its own unique lens for studying cognition and social life.

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